

NOVO'S NEW INTEREST

A similar approach is visible at Novo Nordisk, which is deepening its focus on next-generation metabolic therapies, multi-hormone combinations and expanded indications as competition builds in obesity and diabetes therapies, including in India.

Vikrant Shrotriya, Managing Director of Novo Nordisk India, says the company's priority is to ensure that cardiometabolic innovations for chronic diseases are "available, accessible and sustainable for people in India." He says the company is prioritising its recombinant-DNA-based GLP-1 portfolio, advanced manufacturing, quality and safety standards, competitive pricing, partnerships with local players and access through digital collaborations.

Novo Nordisk is working on higher doses of injectable Semaglutide. Shrotriya cites results from its Phase-3b STEP UP trial, where a 7.2 mg dose delivered 21% weight loss in people with obesity, with one-third of participants losing 25% or more of their weight than they did with a placebo.

A central pillar of Novo Nordisk's longer-term strategy is the development of multi-hormone therapies. Shrotriya says combinations such as GLP-1 and amylin, a peptide hormone, represent the next major phase of metabolic care, particularly in India, where obesity and diabetes coexist in nearly 70% of patients.

Globally, Novo Nordisk invested more than 52 billion Danish krone (\$7.5 billion) in research and development in 2024 and over 129 billion DKK (\$18.7 billion) in production capacity, reflecting the scale of expected demand for metabolic therapies.



The company's next wave of innovation is focused on tailoring therapies to patient subgroups through biomarkers and precision medicine to maximise impact"

Winselov Tucker

President & General Manager,
Eli Lilly and Company (India)



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Vikrant Shrotriya

Managing Director, Novo
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AMGEN'S PLANS

Amgen, which does not yet have a GLP-1 drug on the market, is approaching the obesity market opportunity from a different starting point.

An Amgen spokesperson says the company is developing both oral and injectable medications using incretin and non-incretin gut hormones.

MariTide, a long-acting molecule antibody-peptide conjugate combining a GLP-1 peptide with a monoclonal antibody targeting the glucose-dependent receptor, is central to Amgen's cardiometabolic portfolio.

With patient adherence a key concern, the spokesperson notes that more than 50% of patients discontinue treatment within one

year, and that therapies effective at initiation often become unsustainable over time.

Beyond obesity, Amgen is expanding MariTide into Type 2 diabetes treatments, heart failure, atherosclerotic cardiovascular disease, kidney disease and obstructive sleep apnea. In the longer term, Amgen is also prioritising an integrated cardiometabolic franchise rather than relying on a single blockbuster.

It's clear that the market for treatment of diabetes and obesity is set for a sea change as drug makers accelerate efforts to replace their blockbusters with a more layered portfolio of long-term therapies. **BT**

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